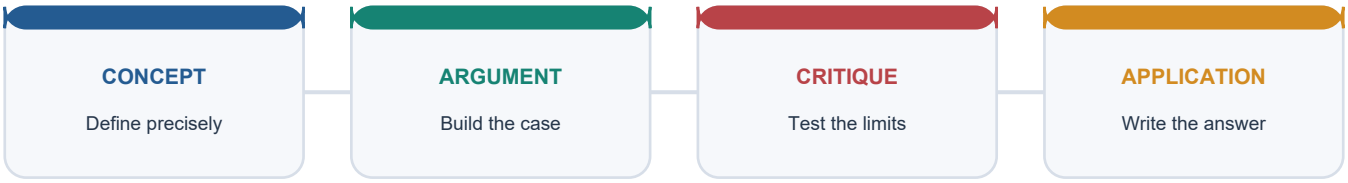
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Provincial & Regional Kingdoms (Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur, Kashmir) + bounded Ahom/Assam Prelims extension - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Provincial & Regional Kingdoms (Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur, Kashmir) + bounded Ahom/Assam Prelims extension - Solved Practice Workbook

> **Standalone workbook.** This companion carries the complete 32-item objective-practice bank, the routed PYQ practice and the six original Mains models. It is read alongside, and shares no duplicated MCQ bank with, `Learning-Session.md`, whose Basic MCQ section is limited to its own 16 Learning MCQs.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Question: Which explanation best accounts for Bengal's ability to retain autonomy after Firuz Tughlaq's campaigns?

- A. Distance, difficult land-water communications and climate combined with Ilyas Shahi organisation and the Ekdala strategy.
- B. A complete absence of trade routes connecting the delta to other regions.
- C. The permanent deployment of a Lodi governor at Pandua.
- D. Mandu's plateau fortifications blocking every approach to Bengal.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Ecology raised the cost of projection, while dynasty and strategy made autonomy durable.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Ecology raised the cost of projection, while dynasty and strategy made autonomy durable.
- B. **Incorrect.** Bengal's delta was commercially connected through Chittagong, textiles and Chinese contact, so 'no trade routes' contradicts the evidence.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Lodis rose to power in Delhi only in 1451, decades after this campaign sequence, and no Lodi governor sat at Pandua.
- D. **Incorrect.** Mandu is Malwa's capital on a separate plateau far to the west; it has no defensive role in Bengal's delta.

Trap: Gift exchange and the Kosi boundary settlement did not make Bengal subordinate to Delhi.

Workbook MCQ 02

Question: Which sequence correctly identifies Ilyas Shah's consolidation?

- A. He abolished jizyah in Kashmir after Sikandar Shah.
- B. He captured Lakhnauti and Sonargaon in 1342 and ruled as Shamsuddin Ilyas Shah.
- C. He shifted Malwa's capital from Dhar to Mandu.
- D. He founded Ahmedabad after annexing Jaunpur in 1484.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It correctly attaches ruler, places and date to Bengal's consolidation.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The jizyah abolition after Sikandar Shah belongs to Zainul Abidin's Kashmir, an entirely different ruler and kingdom.
- B. **Correct.** It correctly attaches ruler, places and date to Bengal's consolidation.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Dhar-to-Mandu capital shift belongs to Malwa's Ghuri rulers, not to Bengal's Ilyas Shah.
- D. **Incorrect.** Ahmedabad was founded by Ahmad Shah I of Gujarat in 1413, and Jaunpur's 1484 annexation belongs to Bahlul Lodi -- neither event involves Ilyas Shah.

Trap: Ahmedabad belongs to Ahmad Shah I and Jaunpur's annexation to Bahlul Lodi, not to Ilyas Shah.

Workbook MCQ 03

Question: What is the most careful use of the Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah justice anecdote?

- A. It proves that Bengal had no social hierarchy or legal inequality.
- B. It is irrelevant because court stories never contain historical information.
- C. It reveals a courtly ideal of justice and should be read with trade, diplomacy and other evidence rather than as a social census.
- D. It establishes that Ghiyasuddin was a Gujarat ruler who founded Ahmedabad.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The anecdote is evidence of a normative legitimacy claim, not a statistical record.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** A single courtly anecdote cannot certify the absence of hierarchy or legal inequality across an entire kingdom.
- B. **Incorrect.** Court narratives are genuine evidence of ideals and legitimacy claims; dismissing them entirely discards a usable source category.
- C. **Correct.** The anecdote is evidence of a normative legitimacy claim, not a statistical record.
- D. **Incorrect.** Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah ruled Bengal (1389-1409); Ahmedabad was founded by Ahmad Shah I of Gujarat, a different ruler and kingdom.

Trap: A justice story can be historically meaningful, but it cannot establish universal legal experience.

Workbook MCQ 04

Question: Which feature most securely identifies the mature regional idiom at Gaur and Pandua?

- A. Lofty gates and huge arches associated with the Sharqi idiom at Jaunpur.
- B. Slender stone turrets and ornate brackets derived from Gujarat's Jain craft tradition.
- C. Massive high-plinth buildings with coloured glazed tiles characteristic of Mandu.
- D. Brick and mortar, broad sloping arches, curvilinear roofs and locally adapted decorative motifs.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is the Bengal idiom described in the source for Gaur and Pandua.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Lofty gates and huge arches are the Sharqi idiom of Jaunpur, not the brick-based Bengal idiom.
- B. **Incorrect.** Slender turrets and ornate brackets are Gujarat's Jain-influenced stone idiom, a different material tradition from Bengal's brick.
- C. **Incorrect.** High plinths and glazed tiles describe Mandu's Malwa idiom, built in stone on a plateau, not Bengal's riverine brick architecture.
- D. **Correct.** This is the Bengal idiom described in the source for Gaur and Pandua.

Trap: Do not transpose Jaunpur's, Gujarat's or Malwa's architectural vocabulary onto Bengal's brick-and-terracotta idiom.

Workbook MCQ 05

Question: Which statement best describes Alauddin Hussain Shah's relevance to Bengal?

- A. His reign combined a new dynastic phase with Bengali literary patronage, recruitment of Hindus to high office and expansion towards Chittagong-Arakan.
- B. He was Mahmud Begarha's successor who captured Girnar and Champaner.
- C. He founded the Tai-Ahom polity at Charaideo.
- D. He was the Sharqi ruler annexed by Bahlul Lodi in 1484.

Answer: A.

Explanation: It connects post-succession consolidation, patronage, incorporation and external policy.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** It connects post-succession consolidation, patronage, incorporation and external policy.
- B. **Incorrect.** Girnar and Champaner belong to Mahmud Begarha's Gujarat, a separate kingdom and dynasty from Hussain Shah's Bengal.
- C. **Incorrect.** Charaideo and the Tai-Ahom polity belong to the bounded Assam extension under Siu-kha-pha, not to Bengal's Husain Shahi dynasty.
- D. **Incorrect.** The ruler annexed by Bahlul Lodi in 1484 was the last independent Sharqi of Jaunpur, not Hussain Shah of Bengal.

Trap: Jaunpur's Sharqi kingdom -- not Bengal -- was annexed by Bahlul Lodi in 1484.

Workbook MCQ 06

Question: Why should Gujarat's 1407 independence be distinguished from Ahmad Shah I's rule?

- A. The distinction concerns only the shape of Charaideo moidams.
- B. Formal independence under Muzaffar Shah preceded Ahmad Shah's consolidation of nobles, administration and Ahmedabad as a capital.
- C. 1407 ended all rivalries with Malwa and Mewar.
- D. Ahmad Shah ruled Bengal before Ilyas Shah.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Proclamation and durable state-building are separate historical processes.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Charaideo's moidams belong to the bounded Ahom/Assam extension and have no connection to Gujarat's 1407 proclamation.
- B. **Correct.** Proclamation and durable state-building are separate historical processes.
- C. **Incorrect.** Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry continued for decades after 1407 and remained central to the topic's balance-of-power narrative.
- D. **Incorrect.** Ahmad Shah ruled Gujarat, not Bengal, and Ilyas Shah's Bengal consolidation (1342) predates Ahmad Shah's reign (1411-42).

Trap: Independence changed Gujarat's political status, but Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry remained an active, ongoing contest.

Workbook MCQ 07

Question: Which combination best captures Mahmud Begarha's statecraft?

- A. He was a Kashmir ruler who restored temples and abolished jizyah.
- B. He relied on Bengal's Kosi boundary and never intervened in Saurashtra.
- C. He pursued Girnar and Champaner, made route security a concern through inns and caravanserais, and faced Portuguese interference in trade.
- D. He confined Gujarat to Patan and abandoned all commercial routes.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It joins strategic conquest, route security and maritime pressure into one coherent statecraft.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Restoring temples and abolishing jizyah describes Zainul Abidin of Kashmir, a different ruler and region entirely.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Kosi boundary belongs to the Bengal-Delhi settlement after Firuz's campaigns; Begarha's central strategic concern was Saurashtra, including Girnar, not Bengal.
- C. **Correct.** It joins strategic conquest, route security and maritime pressure into one coherent statecraft.

- D. **Incorrect.** Begarha moved beyond Patan to build Girnar/Mustafabad and Champaner and actively protected trade routes; he did not abandon commerce.

Trap: Boundaries matter across the topic, but the Kosi settlement belongs to Bengal-Delhi relations, not to Gujarat.

Workbook MCQ 08

Question: Which statement correctly separates the two Gujarati Portuguese episodes?

- A. Bahadur Shah, not Begarha, founded Ahmedabad in 1413.
- B. The Portuguese affected only inland Malwa and never Gujarat's coast.
- C. Mahmud Begarha made the Bassein concession while facing Ilyas Shah.
- D. Mahmud Begarha is linked to earlier resistance; Bahadur Shah's later Bassein-Diu position must be read with pressure from Humayun.

Answer: D.

Explanation: It preserves chronology and multi-directional pressure across two distinct reigns.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Ahmedabad was founded in 1413 by Ahmad Shah I, more than a century before Bahadur Shah's reign (1526-37).
- B. **Incorrect.** The Portuguese pressure was specifically maritime and coastal, striking Gujarat's west-coast ports such as Diu and Bassein, not inland Malwa.
- C. **Incorrect.** Ilyas Shah ruled Bengal in the fourteenth century, more than a century before the Bassein-Diu episode, and had no connection to it.
- D. **Correct.** It preserves chronology and multi-directional pressure across two distinct reigns.

Trap: The Portuguese connection is genuinely relevant, but it wrongly assigns Bahadur Shah's later constrained position to Begarha.

Workbook MCQ 09

Question: Why was Malwa a strategic hinge?

- A. Its plateau commanded routes between Gujarat, north India and the north-south corridor, making it relevant to Gujarat, Mewar, Bahmanis and Lodis.
- B. It was an isolated coast with no connection to Rajasthan.
- C. It controlled the only route from China to Chittagong.
- D. Its importance rested exclusively on poetic patronage at Jaunpur.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Route command explains Malwa's repeated political salience to multiple neighbouring powers.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Route command explains Malwa's repeated political salience to multiple neighbouring powers.
- B. **Incorrect.** Malwa is a landlocked plateau, not a coast, and it was directly connected to Rajasthan through Chanderi and neighbouring routes.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Bengal-China maritime and riverine route via Chittagong has no connection to Malwa's inland plateau geography.
- D. **Incorrect.** Poetic and scholarly patronage describes Jaunpur's Sharqi court, a separate kingdom with a different basis for its regional importance.

Trap: Cultural patronage mattered in regional states generally, but Jaunpur's reputation cannot explain Malwa's geography.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Which evidence best illustrates Hushang Shah's relationship with commercial groups?

- A. He instituted Paik rotation in the Brahmaputra valley.
- B. He patronised Jains, important merchants and bankers; Nardeva Soni appears as treasurer and adviser.
- C. He made Ma Huan the chief minister of Bengal.
- D. He ordered the Lodi annexation of Jaunpur in 1484.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It offers a named, concrete link between the Malwa court and commercial personnel.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Paik rotation is the Ahom/Assam extension's service institution, unconnected to Malwa's Hushang Shah.
- B. **Correct.** It offers a named, concrete link between the Malwa court and commercial personnel.
- C. **Incorrect.** Ma Huan was a Chinese interpreter-traveller who documented Bengal's trade; he never served in Bengal's or any other court as a minister.
- D. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur's 1484 annexation was ordered by Bahlul Lodi of Delhi, not by Hushang Shah of Malwa, who ruled decades earlier.

Trap: Ma Huan is connected to trade evidence, but as an outside observer, not as anyone's minister.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: What is the safest interpretation of Mahmud Khalji's temple destruction in conflicts with Mewar and neighbouring rulers?

- A. It establishes that Malwa was permanently subject to Gujarat.
- B. It proves that every Malwa ruler followed one unchanging policy.
- C. It must be read in its wartime context; particular campaigns do not by themselves establish a general policy across all Malwa rule.
- D. It can be ignored because military evidence never matters.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It neither erases the violence nor overgeneralises from a specific campaign.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Malwa fought Gujarat as often as it cooperated with it; the episode does not establish permanent subjection to Gujarat.
- B. **Incorrect.** Hushang Shah's toleration of Rajputs and Jain merchants shows a materially different policy from Mahmud Khalji's wartime conduct within the same dynasty.
- C. **Correct.** It neither erases the violence nor overgeneralises from a specific campaign.
- D. **Incorrect.** Military conduct is directly relevant evidence for a ruler's statecraft and cannot be waved aside as irrelevant.

Trap: Mahmud Khalji is politically significant, but Hushang Shah's different policies show real variation within Malwa's rulers.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Which event best demonstrates how Malwa's internal contest altered the wider balance?

- A. The Kosi treaty between Firuz and Ilyas Shah.
- B. Alauddin Hussain Shah's patronage of Bengali writers.
- C. Zainul Abidin's restoration of Kashmir's libraries.
- D. Mahmud II's conflict with Medini Rai drew in Rana Sanga and Gujarat, while the Lodis watched Chanderi and Malwa.

Answer: D.

Explanation: A factional dispute inside Malwa connected directly to Mewar, Gujarat and Lodi interests.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The Kosi treaty is a Bengal-Delhi boundary settlement from the fourteenth century, unrelated to Malwa's sixteenth-century succession crisis.
- B. **Incorrect.** Hussain Shah's literary patronage is a Bengal cultural fact with no bearing on Malwa's internal political balance.
- C. **Incorrect.** Zainul Abidin's library restoration is a Kashmir cultural measure, disconnected from the Malwa-Mewar-Gujarat-Lodi contest.
- D. **Correct.** A factional dispute inside Malwa connected directly to Mewar, Gujarat and Lodi interests.

Trap: This is also a boundary-settlement question in the topic, but the Kosi treaty belongs to Bengal's earlier relationship with Delhi.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Why are the Sharqis called the Sharqis?

- A. Their founder Malik Sarwar held the title Malik-us-Sharq, lord of the east.
- B. They founded the Ilyas Shahi line at Pandua.
- C. They governed Saurashtra from the fort of Girnar.
- D. They were the first Tai-Ahom chroniclers at Charaideo.

Answer: A.

Explanation: It explains a dynastic label through a precise political title.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** It explains a dynastic label through a precise political title.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Ilyas Shahi line is Bengal's dynasty founded by Ilyas Shah, an entirely separate lineage from the Sharqis of Jaunpur.
- C. **Incorrect.** Girnar and Saurashtra belong to Gujarat's Mahmud Begarha, not to the Sharqis of the Ganga valley.
- D. **Incorrect.** Tai-Ahom chroniclers produced the Buranjis in the Brahmaputra valley, an unrelated polity and region to Jaunpur's Sharqis.

Trap: Both are eastern regional dynasties, but the Ilyas Shahi line belongs specifically to Bengal, not Jaunpur.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Which description of Jaunpur is most accurate?

- A. A plateau capital of Malwa built around glazed tiles.
- B. A Ganga-valley Sharqi kingdom with territorial reach, a distinctive idiom of lofty gates and arches, and a learned reputation as the Shiraz of the East.
- C. A Kashmir valley court ruled by Zainul Abidin.
- D. A small coastal settlement dependent upon Portuguese customs.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It joins territorial, architectural and cultural dimensions correctly for Jaunpur.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Glazed tiles and a plateau capital describe Mandu in Malwa, a different kingdom with a different material idiom from Jaunpur's arches.
- B. **Correct.** It joins territorial, architectural and cultural dimensions correctly for Jaunpur.
- C. **Incorrect.** Zainul Abidin ruled the valley kingdom of Kashmir, an entirely separate polity from the Ganga-valley Sharqi state.
- D. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur is an inland Ganga-valley territorial power with no coastline and no Portuguese-customs dependency.

Trap: Mandu in Malwa is a genuine regional architectural description, but it belongs to a different kingdom than Jaunpur.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: What does Bahlul Lodi's 1484 annexation of Jaunpur show?

- A. Bengal's delta had become directly governed by Delhi.
- B. The Portuguese had conquered Ahmedabad.
- C. The earlier balance was changing as the Lodis extended control in the Ganga valley; Sharqi cultural memory could outlast sovereignty.
- D. All regional cultural traditions vanished with a single battle.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It states both a real political break and a genuine cultural continuity.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Bengal remained a separate, autonomous sultanate under the Husain Shahi line; the 1484 annexation concerned Jaunpur, not Bengal.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Portuguese never conquered Ahmedabad; their pressure on Gujarat came later, through coastal positions such as Diu and Bassein.
- C. **Correct.** It states both a real political break and a genuine cultural continuity.
- D. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur's architectural and learned traditions ('Shiraz of the East') persisted as cultural memory well after 1484's political annexation.

Trap: Annexation was decisive for sovereignty, but it did not erase Jaunpur's architectural and learned traditions.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Which contrast is correct for Kashmir?

- A. Zainul Abidin ruled before the 1320 Mongol attack.
- B. The Rishi tradition proves that coercion was impossible in Kashmir.
- C. Sikandar and Zainul Abidin followed identical policies toward temples, jizyah and returning non-Muslims.
- D. Sikandar Shah's coercive phase should be distinguished from Zainul Abidin's reversals, restorations and broader reconciliation.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The contrast between the two reigns is precisely the historical point to be tested.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Zainul Abidin ruled 1420-70, roughly a century after the 1320 Mongol attack, not before it.
- B. **Incorrect.** A syncretic Rishi tradition can coexist with periods of coercion under a different ruler; one does not logically rule out the other.
- C. **Incorrect.** Sikandar Shah is remembered for persecution and temple actions, while Zainul Abidin explicitly reversed those very orders -- their policies were opposite, not identical.

- D. **Correct.** The contrast between the two reigns is precisely the historical point to be tested.

Trap: Both rulers belong to Kashmir, but their policies are specifically presented in the source as sharply different.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Which named evidence best supports an argument that Zainul Abidin linked legitimacy with social and economic reconstruction?

- A. Restoration of grants and temples, return of non-Muslims, high office for Hindus, translation patronage and encouragement of crafts and agriculture.
- B. Girnar, Champaner and Portuguese resistance.
- C. The Kosi boundary and Ekdala fort.
- D. Malik Sarwar's title Malik-us-Sharq.

Answer: A.

Explanation: It connects reconciliation to institutions, learning and material activity in one coherent picture.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** It connects reconciliation to institutions, learning and material activity in one coherent picture.
- B. **Incorrect.** Girnar, Champaner and Portuguese resistance are Gujarat's Mahmud Begarha's achievements, unconnected to Kashmir's Zainul Abidin.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Kosi boundary and Ekdala fort belong to Bengal's fourteenth-century conflict with Delhi, not to Kashmir.
- D. **Incorrect.** Malik Sarwar's title explains the Sharqi dynastic name in Jaunpur; it has no bearing on Kashmir's Zainul Abidin.

Trap: This evidence gives a coherent state-building cluster, but it belongs to Gujarat, not Kashmir.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: What can regional architecture securely establish?

- A. That a court's subjects enjoyed equal status regardless of class or community.
- B. That rulers patronised particular materials, crafts, labour and urban forms, which can be related to political geography when cross-checked.
- C. That every building was made only by the ruler's own religious community.
- D. That a single monument fixes the exact boundary of a kingdom.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Material culture can show patronage and technique when read alongside other evidence.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Architecture can be socially meaningful evidence of patronage, but it cannot certify equal status for every subject or community.
- B. **Correct.** Material culture can show patronage and technique when read alongside other evidence.
- C. **Incorrect.** Regional courts regularly drew on craft traditions (Jain stone-carving in Gujarat, for instance) outside the ruler's own community, so sole authorship by one community is unsupportable.
- D. **Incorrect.** A monument shows patronage and capital investment at one site; it cannot by itself define a kingdom's precise territorial boundary.

Trap: Architecture can be socially meaningful, but it is never a census of equality across a kingdom.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: Which is the strongest evidence ladder for Bengal's external connection?

- A. One architectural photograph without date or context.
- B. A later courtly title alone.
- C. Chinese diplomatic contact, Ma Huan's perspective, Chittagong, textiles and re-export, interpreted with the limit of each source.
- D. An assertion that delta states cannot participate in oceanic trade.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It triangulates diplomacy, trade nodes and an observer's account while retaining an explicit limit.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** An undated, uncontextualised image cannot by itself establish an external commercial connection.
- B. **Incorrect.** A courtly title indicates status or legitimacy, not commercial connectivity, and cannot substitute for named trade evidence.
- C. **Correct.** It triangulates diplomacy, trade nodes and an observer's account while retaining an explicit limit.
- D. **Incorrect.** This assertion is directly contradicted by the source, which documents Bengal's ocean-going ships, Chittagong's growth and Chinese re-export trade.

Trap: Courtly titles can indicate legitimacy, but they cannot alone demonstrate commercial connection.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which statement best defines the fifteenth-century balance of power?

- A. A single Delhi army controlling every regional court.
- B. A world in which states never intervened beyond their capitals.
- C. A formal federation with a written constitution binding Gujarat, Malwa, Mewar, Bengal and Jaunpur.
- D. A recurring pattern of checks among regional powers, shaped by rivalry, alliances and contested corridors rather than fixed modern borders.

Answer: D.

Explanation: It treats balance as a pattern of interaction, not a fixed institutional arrangement.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Delhi's contraction is precisely why regional courts such as Gujarat, Malwa, Bengal and Jaunpur governed independently rather than under one army.
- B. **Incorrect.** Gujarat, Malwa and Mewar repeatedly intervened in one another's succession disputes through rival factions and border-state alignments.
- C. **Incorrect.** No written constitution or federation existed; the relationship was a recurring pattern of rivalry, alliance and intervention, not a formal legal union.
- D. **Correct.** It treats balance as a pattern of interaction, not a fixed institutional arrangement.

Trap: The states were interconnected, but there was no federation or fixed constitutional equality among them.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: What is the appropriate place of the Ahom case in this topic?

- A. A bounded comparison showing Brahmaputra-valley state formation beyond the Delhi-centred provincial system.
- B. A detailed survey of every funerary architectural form at Charaideo.
- C. Evidence that Paik service operated under the Sharqis.
- D. A substitute for studying Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur and Kashmir.

Answer: A.

Explanation: It broadens comparison without displacing the five core regional-state cases.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** It broadens comparison without displacing the five core regional-state cases.
- B. **Incorrect.** Detailed funerary form, cosmology and conservation at Charaideo are deliberately routed to Art & Culture, not treated in full within this History unit.
- C. **Incorrect.** Paik service is specific to the Ahom polity in the Brahmaputra valley; the Sharqis of Jaunpur operated under a separate court and revenue system.
- D. **Incorrect.** The Ahom extension is a bounded addition, not a replacement for the topic's five core kingdoms.

Trap: Charaideo is genuinely relevant, but its detailed funerary form is deliberately routed to Art & Culture.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: Which statement most accurately describes Paik organisation for this bounded extension?

- A. A coin used for north Indian land revenue accounts.
- B. A rotational service arrangement linking adult male subjects or households to labour and military mobilisation.
- C. A Bengali brick architectural feature.
- D. A title held by the Gujarat governor of Saurashtra.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This avoids reducing an institutional obligation to a vague labour label.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Paik is a service obligation, not a coin or fiscal-accounting term used anywhere in the Delhi Sultanate's revenue system.
- B. **Correct.** This avoids reducing an institutional obligation to a vague labour label.
- C. **Incorrect.** Brick architectural features belong to Bengal's Gaur-Pandua idiom, an unrelated material-culture category from Paik service.
- D. **Incorrect.** Girnar's governorship in Saurashtra belongs to Gujarat's Begarha-era administration, not to the Ahom Paik system.

Trap: Fiscal vocabulary matters elsewhere in the topic, but Paik is a service organisation, not coinage.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: How should Buranjis be used?

- A. Only as decorative evidence for moidam art.
- B. As neutral transcripts that need no contextual reading.
- C. As royal chronicles useful for sequence and institutional detail, read with awareness of court perspective and silences.
- D. As proof that Assam was an administrative division of the Lodis.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This states both the chronicle's utility and its necessary limitation.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Buranjis are textual chronicles of politics and institutions, not decorative evidence for the separate discipline of funerary art.
- B. **Incorrect.** As royal court records, Buranjis inevitably carry a court-centred perspective and cannot be treated as neutral, viewpoint-free transcripts.
- C. **Correct.** This states both the chronicle's utility and its necessary limitation.
- D. **Incorrect.** The Ahom polity in the Brahmaputra valley developed independently of the Delhi Sultanate and the Lodis; it was never a Lodi administrative division.

Trap: Chronicles can be rich evidence, but their royal viewpoint prevents treating them as neutral transcripts.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Which topic boundary is methodologically correct?

- A. Explain the full ritual cosmology of every moidam before discussing Ahom state formation.
- B. Treat World Heritage listing as proof of a political treaty with Delhi.
- C. Use no Charaideo evidence in History because UNESCO is only Art & Culture.
- D. Use Charaideo, Paik and Buranjis here for polity, chronology and sources; route detailed funerary form, cosmology and conservation to Art & Culture.

Answer: D.

Explanation: It preserves an examinable anchor while preventing scope drift into another subject's territory.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Full ritual cosmology is deliberately excluded from this History unit and belongs to the Art & Culture treatment of the same site.
- B. **Incorrect.** UNESCO's World Heritage listing certifies cultural/historical significance criteria; it has no bearing on any political treaty with Delhi.
- C. **Incorrect.** Charaideo's political-administrative evidence -- chronology, Paik and Buranjis -- is legitimately owned by this History unit even though UNESCO also documents the site.
- D. **Correct.** It preserves an examinable anchor while preventing scope drift into another subject's territory.

Trap: Ritual form is genuinely important, but it exceeds this History module's stated boundary.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Which chronology is safest for Gujarat?

- A. Muzaffar Shah -> Ahmad Shah I -> Mahmud Begarha -> Bahadur Shah.
- B. Mahmud Begarha -> Ilyas Shah -> Zainul Abidin -> Bahlul Lodi.
- C. Bahadur Shah -> Muzaffar Shah -> Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah -> Hushang Shah.
- D. Ahmad Shah I -> Malik Sarwar -> Sikandar Shah -> Siu-kha-pha.

Answer: A.

Explanation: This is the correct Gujarat sequence used throughout this package.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** This is the correct Gujarat sequence used throughout this package.
- B. **Incorrect.** Ilyas Shah (Bengal), Zainul Abidin (Kashmir) and Bahlul Lodi (Delhi) are rulers of three separate kingdoms mixed into a false Gujarat sequence.
- C. **Incorrect.** This reverses Gujarat's actual order and inserts Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah (Bengal) and Hushang Shah (Malwa), rulers of different kingdoms entirely.
- D. **Incorrect.** Malik Sarwar (Jaunpur), Sikandar Shah (Kashmir) and Siu-kha-pha (Ahom) are each rulers of different, unrelated polities, not Gujarat.

Trap: Several of these names are genuine medieval rulers, but this option mixes regions and reverses Gujarat's true order.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which example most directly shows that state capacity involved more than conquest?

- A. A monument interpreted without its capital, patron or material context.
- B. Ahmad Shah's control over nobles and administration, urban development at Ahmedabad, and Begarha's concern with safe roads and caravanserais.
- C. A claim that only one battlefield determines a state's history.
- D. A chronological list with no explanation of mechanisms.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It names administrative, urban and route-security dimensions beyond mere conquest.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** A monument stripped of its capital, patron and material context cannot demonstrate an institutional argument about state capacity.
- B. **Correct.** It names administrative, urban and route-security dimensions beyond mere conquest.
- C. **Incorrect.** Reducing a state's history to a single battlefield ignores the administrative, urban and commercial institutions that sustained rule between campaigns.
- D. **Incorrect.** A bare chronological list, without explaining the underlying mechanism, does not show how conquest was converted into durable capacity.

Trap: Conquest mattered, but durable capacity also required institutions and protected movement.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Which statement best applies source criticism to a monument?

- A. A monument removes the need to identify its date, place or patron.
- B. A monument has no historical value because it is not a written text.
- C. A monument can demonstrate patronage, craft and material adaptation; combine it with texts and context before making a claim about society or policy.
- D. A monument proves the private beliefs of every person in the kingdom.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It identifies both the legitimate inference a monument supports and its limit.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Identifying date, place and patron is the first step of source criticism for any monument, not a step that can be skipped.
- B. **Incorrect.** Monuments are material evidence with genuine historical value for patronage, craft and technique, even though they are non-textual.
- C. **Correct.** It identifies both the legitimate inference a monument supports and its limit.
- D. **Incorrect.** A monument reflects its patron's and builders' choices; it cannot certify the private beliefs of every individual subject in the kingdom.

Trap: Monuments can have broad cultural significance, but they cannot reveal every subject's private belief.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which comparative thesis is strongest?

- A. Regional culture was politically irrelevant because states fought wars.
- B. All regional kingdoms followed the identical Delhi administrative model.
- C. Bengal's autonomy was caused only by rain, Gujarat's only by ports, and Malwa's only by a fort.
- D. Regional courts shared the task of converting local resources into authority, but Bengal's delta, Gujarat's commercial network, Malwa's plateau and Ahom service organisation did so by different mechanisms.

Answer: D.

Explanation: It gives a shared analytical frame without flattening the individual cases into one story.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Architecture, language patronage and religious policy were themselves instruments of legitimacy and statecraft, not irrelevant to warfare-era politics.
- B. **Incorrect.** Each regional court adapted Persianate institutions to local conditions -- Bengal's brick idiom, Gujarat's Jain-craft idiom and Malwa's plateau court all differ from a single Delhi model.
- C. **Incorrect.** Single-cause explanations (rain, ports, a fort) erase the institutions, elite coalitions and revenue systems that these courts actually built.
- D. **Correct.** It gives a shared analytical frame without flattening the individual cases into one story.

Trap: Recognising distinct environments is correct, but a single-cause explanation for each state erases institutions and elites.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Which inference about Bengal is defensible?

- A. Its delta location made external conquest costly while waterways, trade and court organisation connected rather than isolated the region.
- B. Its Chinese contact proves that no local languages were patronised.
- C. Its brick architecture proves that all religious conflict was absent.
- D. Its climate alone automatically created an independent dynasty.

Answer: A.

Explanation: It combines geographic constraint, connectivity and political organisation correctly.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** It combines geographic constraint, connectivity and political organisation correctly.
- B. **Incorrect.** Bengal's Chinese diplomatic contact coexisted with active Bengali literary patronage under Ilyas Shahi and Husain Shahi rulers; one does not exclude the other.
- C. **Incorrect.** Brick architecture is evidence of material adaptation and patronage; it cannot certify the total absence of religious or political conflict.
- D. **Incorrect.** Climate raised the cost of external conquest, but Ilyas Shahi organisation and the Ekdala strategy were still required to convert that advantage into a durable dynasty.

Trap: Climate mattered, but environmental conditions alone did not automatically create the Ilyas Shahi state.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: What is the safest answer route for a Diu-related objective question?

- A. Move the episode to Chittagong because both are ports.
- B. Check ruler sequence first: Begarha's resistance is distinct from Bahadur Shah's later constrained Bassein-Diu context, then test the role of Humayun's pressure.
- C. Assume a detailed treaty clause without the original question or official key.
- D. Treat every Gujarat ruler as interchangeable because all were connected to the coast.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It uses chronology and multi-causal context rather than a familiar-name guess.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Diu is on Gujarat's west coast, while Chittagong is Bengal's delta port; they belong to entirely separate kingdoms and cannot be substituted for each other.
- B. **Correct.** It uses chronology and multi-causal context rather than a familiar-name guess.
- C. **Incorrect.** Inventing exact treaty language without a verifiable source converts a routed, honestly labelled inference into a fabricated official answer.
- D. **Incorrect.** Muzaffar Shah, Ahmad Shah I, Mahmud Begarha and Bahadur Shah held Gujarat's throne in sequence with materially different policies; they are not interchangeable.

Trap: Coastal connection is relevant, but this is precisely the ruler-confusion trap the question is designed to test.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Which pairing is correctly matched?

- A. Jaunpur - Jain-derived slender turrets and Ahmedabad's Jama Masjid.
- B. Kashmir - Kosi boundary and Ekdala fort.
- C. Gujarat - fine stonework, brackets and turrets; Bengal - brick and locally adapted roof vocabulary.
- D. Mandu - brick curvilinear roofs and Chittagong re-export.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It correctly distinguishes Gujarat's stone-craft idiom from Bengal's brick adaptation.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Jain-derived turrets and Ahmedabad's Jama Masjid belong to Gujarat, not to Jaunpur's lofty-gate-and-arch idiom.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Kosi boundary and Ekdala fort are Bengal's fourteenth-century features, unconnected to Kashmir's valley polity.
- C. **Correct.** It correctly distinguishes Gujarat's stone-craft idiom from Bengal's brick adaptation.
- D. **Incorrect.** Brick curvilinear roofs belong to Bengal, and Chittagong re-export trade is Bengal's port activity, not Mandu's inland Malwa plateau capital.

Trap: Both are genuine regional architectural styles, but Jaunpur is specifically associated with lofty gates and huge arches.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: What is the most useful forward linkage from Topic 08?

- A. Regionalisation ended all negotiations after 1484.
- B. Only the Ahom extension matters for later imperial history.
- C. Babur entered a political vacuum because no regional court retained resources or memory.
- D. Lodi expansion, the Malwa-Mewar-Gujarat contest and durable regional courts form the setting in which Mughal expansion had to negotiate, defeat or incorporate existing powers.

Answer: D.

Explanation: It turns regionalisation into a genuine transition towards later empire-building.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur's 1484 annexation reorganised the eastern balance, but Gujarat, Malwa, Mewar and Bengal continued negotiating, allying and contesting territory afterward.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Ahom extension is a bounded comparison; Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur and Kashmir remain the core setting for the transition to Mughal-era topics.
- C. **Incorrect.** Delhi's weakness mattered, but the evidence in this topic documents active, resourced regional states, not an empty subcontinent.
- D. **Correct.** It turns regionalisation into a genuine transition towards later empire-building.

Trap: Delhi's weakness mattered, but the evidence shows active regional states rather than a political vacuum for Babur to inherit.

Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs

Predictable error	Correcting Workbook MCQ	Trap it targets
Treating a boundary settlement (Kosi) or gift exchange as subordination	Workbook MCQ 01	Gift exchange and the Kosi boundary settlement did not make Bengal subordinate to Delhi.
Assigning Ahmedabad or Jaunpur's annexation to Ilyas Shah	Workbook MCQ 02	Ahmedabad belongs to Ahmad Shah I and Jaunpur's annexation to Bahlul Lodi, not to Ilyas Shah.
Believing 1407 proclamation alone ended Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry	Workbook MCQ 06	Independence changed Gujarat's political status, but Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry remained an active, ongoing contest.
Merging Begarha's resistance with Bahadur Shah's Bassein-Diu concession	Workbook MCQ 08	The Portuguese connection is genuinely relevant, but it wrongly assigns Bahadur Shah's later constrained position to Begarha.
Confusing Ma Huan (observer) with a court office-holder	Workbook MCQ 10	Ma Huan is connected to trade evidence, but as an outside observer, not as anyone's minister.
Projecting Zainul Abidin's reconciliation backward onto Sikandar Shah	Workbook MCQ 16	Both rulers belong to Kashmir, but their policies are specifically presented in the source as sharply different.
Treating the Ahom case as a full replacement for the five core kingdoms	Workbook MCQ 21	Charaideo is genuinely relevant, but its detailed funerary form is deliberately routed to Art & Culture.
Equating Paik service with a coin, a building feature or chattel slavery	Workbook MCQ 22	Fiscal vocabulary matters elsewhere in the topic, but Paik is a service organisation, not coinage.
Explaining moidam cosmology/conservation inside this History unit instead of routing it to Art & Culture	Workbook MCQ 24	Ritual form is genuinely important, but it exceeds this History module's stated boundary.

Predictable error	Correcting Workbook MCQ	Trap it targets
Reversing or cross-mixing Gujarat's Muzaffar-Ahmad-Begarha-Bahadur sequence	Workbook MCQ 25	Several of these names are genuine medieval rulers, but this option mixes regions and reverses Gujarat's true order.
Guessing a Diu-related Prelims item by coastal association instead of ruler sequence	Workbook MCQ 30	Coastal connection is relevant, but this is precisely the ruler-confusion trap the question is designed to test.
Assuming Babur entered an empty subcontinent rather than an active regional system	Workbook MCQ 32	Delhi's weakness mattered, but the evidence shows active regional states rather than a political vacuum for Babur to inherit.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Routed PYQ practice

Direct routed PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2023 Q49: Gujarat, Portuguese pressure and Diu

PYQ demand (neutral routing): distinguish the Gujarat ruler sequence around Portuguese pressure, Bassein/Diu and the wider context of Humayun.

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Confidence: High. The safe route separates Mahmud Begarha's earlier resistance to Portuguese interference from Bahadur Shah's later constrained Bassein-Diu position when Humayun's threat mattered. Eliminate a choice that assigns the later concession to Begarha, reverses the rulers, or treats the decision as a voluntary expression of uncontested Gujarati strength. The repository does not contain the official option set or readable official key, so this is an evidence-based inference, not an official answer.

Demand decoding: This is a ruler-sequence elimination question; the demand is to separate Mahmud Begarha's era from Bahadur Shah's era around Portuguese pressure and Diu/Bassein, not to recall an isolated fact about either ruler alone.

Executable elimination plan: Build a two-row ruler-context grid -- Begarha: resistance, Egypt alliance, no decisive check; Bahadur Shah: Humayun's pressure, constrained Bassein-Diu concession -- and eliminate any option that swaps rulers or merges the two contexts before selecting.

Why this route earns marks: It keeps two distinct reigns and two distinct forms of pressure (maritime and inland) apart instead of collapsing them into one familiar Gujarat-Portuguese story.

How to strengthen this route: If the original option set becomes locally available, replace the two-row grid with the exact matched option and name precisely which ruler or context the rejected options reverse.

Direct routed PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 Q92: king-dynasty pairs

PYQ demand (neutral routing): test king-dynasty-region discipline for early/medieval pairs relevant to the topic's chronology method.

OFFICIAL KEY UNAVAILABLE LOCALLY - ROUTED, NOT RECONSTRUCTED. Do not invent the original options. Solve by making a four-column check-ruler, dynasty, region and sequence-and eliminate a pair that crosses Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur or adjacent regional traditions. Confidence in the method is high; confidence in any unpreserved option answer would be false precision.

Demand decoding: An unseen king-dynasty-region matching item tests whether Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur and adjacent regional dynasties are correctly paired without cross-contamination between kingdoms or centuries.

Executable elimination plan: For every option, complete the four-column check (ruler, dynasty, region, sequence) before deciding; do not select a pair on the strength of a familiar ruler's name alone.

Why this route earns marks: It applies a repeatable, source-safe method to an unseen pairing question instead of guessing from partial recall.

How to strengthen this route: If the exact original pair set is later located, name the specific dynasty-region mismatch inside each rejected pairing instead of relying on the general four-column check alone.

Direct routed PYQ 3 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2023 Q45: medieval dynasties and foundation periods

PYQ demand (neutral routing): distinguish founding-period and region associations for Hoysala, Gahadavala, Kakatiya and Yadava traditions.

OFFICIAL KEY UNAVAILABLE LOCALLY - ROUTED, NOT RECONSTRUCTED. This is an adjacent chronology drill, not a licence to fabricate a solved paper. Use a time-place grid, remove options that transpose Deccan and Ganga-valley contexts, and keep it distinct from Topic 08's Bengal-Gujarat-Malwa-Jaunpur-Kashmir core. Confidence: medium for the local routing, not an official-key claim.

Demand decoding: This adjacent-chronology item tests founding-period discipline for Hoysala, Gahadavala, Kakatiya and Yadava traditions, not Bengal-Gujarat-Malwa-Jaunpur-Kashmir facts directly, and must not be conflated with Topic 08's own dynastic sequence.

Executable elimination plan: Draw a time-place grid for the four named dynasties (Deccan versus Ganga-valley location, and approximate founding century) and eliminate any option that transposes a Deccan dynasty's founding period onto a north Indian one, or vice versa.

Why this route earns marks: It keeps the adjacent item's four named dynasties in their correct region and century instead of borrowing Topic 08's own core chronology by mistake.

How to strengthen this route: Once solved, tag this item explicitly as adjacent-owned in revision notes so it is not mistaken for a Topic 08 core-kingdom fact later.

Original solved Mains practice

Question M1. Analyse why the fifteenth century should be understood as regional state formation rather than merely the decline of the Delhi Sultanate. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Delhi's contraction redistributed sovereignty; it did not create an institutional vacuum. Regional courts made authority durable by connecting local geography, elites and resources.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's 1338 break and Ilyas Shah's 1342 capture of Lakhnauti and Sonargaon show a delta court using costly communications and Ekdala-style defence to resist Delhi. Gujarat's 1407 formal break was followed by Ahmad Shah I's control of nobles, Ahmedabad and an urban-commercial base. Malwa's Mandu plateau commanded trunk routes, while Sharqi Jaunpur combined Ganga-valley administration with learned prestige. These are positive capacities, not residual fragments.

Qualification and verdict. The system remained contested: Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry, Malwa factionalism and Bahlul's 1484 annexation of Jaunpur show that autonomy was neither uniform nor permanent. Yet the evidence supports a plural regional state-system, not a simple narrative of collapse.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses four named cases, explains mechanisms and qualifies durability.

Demand decoding: "Analyse" requires isolating the mechanism that converted Delhi's contraction into durable regional capacity using at least two contrasting cases, not merely describing "decline" and stopping there.

Executable answer/compression plan: 150 words = a 2-sentence thesis, then Bengal and Gujarat as the two lead cases (~40 words each), then Malwa or Jaunpur as a contrasting third case, then a 2-sentence qualified verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the Ahom case as a fifth, briefly bounded comparison only if space remains after the four-state core is complete, and always keep Bahlul's 1484 annexation as the explicit counter-fact to "permanent autonomy."

Question M2. Examine architecture and literary patronage as instruments of regional legitimacy. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Regional courts used buildings and patronage to make sovereignty visible in local idioms and to attract cultural networks.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's Gaur-Pandua idiom used brick, broad sloping arches and curvilinear roofs; patronage of Maladhar Basu and later Bengali writers linked courtly authority with local language. Ahmad Shah I's Ahmedabad drew on Jain/Gujarati stone craft-brackets, carving and turrets-while concentrating bazaars, mosques and madrasas. Sharqi Jaunpur's lofty gates, huge arches and "Shiraz of the East" reputation converted scholarship and saintly networks into political prestige. Mandu's high plinths and glazed tiles marked a strategically placed capital.

Qualification and verdict. Buildings prove patronage, material and craft traditions, not complete social integration. Read with political geography and texts, they show culture functioning as statecraft rather than decorative excess.

Why this earns marks: It gives four named examples, turns form into analysis and states a source limit.

Demand decoding: "Examine" requires converting material examples into an argument about political legitimacy, not a monument-by-monument description of style.

Executable answer/compression plan: 150 words = a 1-sentence thesis, then four named examples (Bengal, Gujarat, Jaunpur, Malwa), each compressed into a single evidence-plus-function sentence, then a 1-2 sentence limit on what buildings can and cannot prove.

How to improve this answer: Where marks allow, add Kashmir's translation and craft patronage as a fifth, non-architectural legitimacy example, showing the same mechanism working through language rather than stone.

Question M3. Discuss how geography and political economy shaped the capacities of Bengal, Gujarat and Malwa. (15 marks, 200 words)

Model solution

Claim. Geography mattered through routes, revenue, logistics and institutions; it was not an automatic cause of political success.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's distance, humid climate and difficult land-water communications raised the cost of Delhi's campaigns. Ilyas Shah and Ekdala converted that constraint into autonomy, while waterways, textiles and Chittagong linked the delta to Chinese and wider maritime exchange. Gujarat combined fertile land, handicrafts, Ahmedabad and west-coast ports. Ahmad Shah I's capital and Mahmud Begarha's caravanserais, safe roads and campaigns in Saurashtra show a court protecting the commercial chain from interior production to sea trade. Malwa's plateau between the Narmada and Tapti commanded north-west-south corridors; Mandu therefore mattered to Gujarat, Mewar, Bahmanis and Lodis.

Qualification and verdict. Bengal was not isolated, Gujarat was not powerful through ports alone, and Malwa's strategic position also intensified factional and external conflict. The comparison shows three different routes to capacity-riverine, commercial and corridor-based-within one regional state-system.

Why this earns marks: It compares rather than lists, supplies six named evidence points and rejects environmental determinism.

Demand decoding: "Discuss" three named kingdoms together requires one comparative verdict about geography and political economy, not three disconnected mini-essays.

Executable answer/compression plan: 200 words = a 1-sentence thesis, then three paired evidence-mechanism blocks (Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa) at roughly 50 words each, then a comparative closing sentence naming the three distinct capacity routes.

How to improve this answer: Name the three capacity routes explicitly in one labelled closing phrase -- riverine (Bengal), commercial (Gujarat), corridor-based (Malwa) -- to make the comparative verdict unmistakable to the examiner.

Question M4. "The balance of power in fifteenth-century north India was both stabilising and fragile." Discuss. (15 marks, 200 words)

Model solution

Claim. Regional checks prevented easy concentration of power, yet the same rivalries and internal factions made the system unstable and open to reorganisation.

Named evidence -> analysis. Gujarat, Malwa and Mewar checked one another because Malwa's corridors and Rajasthan's border states mattered to all three. Muzaffar Shah's treatment of Hushang Shah, later intervention

through rival factions, and Rana Kumbha's rise show that influence could be pursued without stable frontier change. In the east, Bengal was checked by Orissa and Jaunpur; the Sharqis maintained a large Ganga-valley kingdom and constrained Bengal's advance. Bahlul Lodi's 1484 annexation of Jaunpur then changed this balance. In Malwa, Mahmud II's conflict with Medini Rai drew in Rana Sanga and Gujarat; Lodi concern over Chanderi shows how a local succession conflict became a north Indian issue.

Qualification and verdict. "Balance" was not a formal alliance system or a peaceful equilibrium. It was a recurring pattern of constraint, whose fragility lay in changing elite coalitions and expanding rivals. This is why the Lodi-Mughal transition must be read against active regional politics.

Why this earns marks: The answer defines the term, demonstrates both sides with named events and reaches a qualified judgement.

Demand decoding: Discussing a quoted claim about "balance of power" requires defining the term first, then testing it against evidence for both the stabilising side and the fragile side before judging it.

Executable answer/compression plan: 200 words = a 1-sentence definition of "balance," then two stabilising examples (the west and east triangles) and two fragility examples (the Malwa succession crisis, the 1484 annexation), then a 1-sentence qualified verdict.

How to improve this answer: Use the precise phrase "a recurring pattern of constraint" once in the opening sentence, rather than the vaguer word "balance" alone, to signal exact terminology to the examiner.

Question M5. Assess the place of trade in the strength and vulnerability of Bengal and Gujarat. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Trade multiplied state capacity when courts connected production, transport, towns and security; it also made valuable routes vulnerable to coercion and competition.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's waterways were an internal transport system as well as a defensive environment. Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah's Chinese contact, Chittagong's growth, ocean-going ships, fine textiles and re-export of Chinese goods show a delta court participating in external circuits. Alauddin Hussain Shah's push towards Chittagong and Arakan further shows that control of a port could be politically valuable. Yet this does not make trade independent of power: court organisation, urban centres and agrarian production sustained the circuit.

Gujarat's fertile land and handicrafts supplied a different commercial chain. Ahmad Shah I's Ahmedabad concentrated markets and craft, while its ports carried much of north India's sea trade. Mahmud Begarha's effort to secure roads, build caravanserais and act against piracy demonstrates the institutional side of commerce. Portuguese interference in West Asian trade exposed the coast's value; Begarha's unsuccessful anti-Portuguese effort must be separated from Bahadur Shah's later constrained Bassein-Diu position under pressure that included Humayun.

Qualification and verdict. Neither port data nor court claims license invented trade volumes or an assumption that all producers prospered equally. Trade was embedded in labour, credit, protection and political strategy. It made both Bengal and Gujarat resilient regional powers, while creating prized nodes through which outside pressure could operate.

Why this earns marks: It gives a two-way assessment, uses named evidence across both cases, preserves the Diu chronology and avoids unsupported data.

Demand decoding: "Assess" requires a genuinely two-sided judgement -- strength and vulnerability -- for both Bengal and Gujarat, not a one-sided celebration of trade.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = a 1-sentence thesis, a Bengal block (~90 words: China contact, Chittagong, textiles), a Gujarat block (~90 words: Ahmedabad, caravanserais, Portuguese pressure), then a closing 2-sentence assessment naming the shared vulnerability mechanism.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit sentence stating the source limit -- no revenue or trade-volume figures are locally available -- to pre-empt an examiner's expectation of invented numbers.

Question M6. Compare the Delhi-centred regional state-system with the bounded Ahom/Assam extension. How should Buranjis and Charaideo be used? (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. The Ahom case broadens the study of state formation without turning Assam into a delayed province of Delhi or replacing the Bengal-Gujarat-Malwa-Jaunpur-Kashmir comparison.

Named evidence -> analysis. In the north Indian system, Bengal's Ilyas Shahi court drew capacity from delta mobility and trade; Gujarat from hinterland, Ahmedabad and ports; Malwa from plateau corridors; Jaunpur from Ganga-valley reach and cultural capital; Kashmir from a distinctive valley polity. The Tai-Ahom entered the Brahmaputra valley under Siu-kha-pha in the thirteenth century, and Charaideo became the first capital and royal necropolis. Paik rotation connected households or adult male subjects to labour and military mobilisation, illustrating a service-based capacity that cannot be reduced to port wealth or Delhi's provincial administration.

Buranjis are royal chronicles: they can supply sequence, institutional vocabulary and court decisions, but their perspective requires cross-questioning. UNESCO's live property page verifies 90 royal moidams at Charaideo from the thirteenth to nineteenth centuries. In this answer, that is evidence for royal memory, chronology and the relevance of Buranjis.

Qualification and verdict. Do not call Paik chattel slavery, or use World Heritage status as a substitute for historical analysis. Detailed moidam form, cosmology and conservation belong to Art & Culture. Within this boundary, the Ahom case demonstrates plural political ecology and improves, rather than dilutes, the regional-state thesis.

Why this earns marks: It maintains the scope boundary, compares mechanisms, treats sources critically and ends with a precise verdict.

Demand decoding: "Compare... how should X be used?" is a two-part directive: it needs both a comparative argument about state formation and an explicit source-method answer for Buranjis and Charaideo.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = a 1-sentence thesis, a five-state summary (~80 words), the Ahom case (~80 words), an explicit Buranji/Charaideo source-method paragraph (~60 words), then a 1-sentence boundary verdict.

How to improve this answer: State the Art & Culture boundary line explicitly in the final sentence, since a compare-and-use-of-sources question is graded partly on correct source discipline, not only on comparative content.